

Taming the AI Juggernaut



Till a few years ago, terms like artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML) were relatively unknown in a world beyond deep tech. As technology leapfrogs and becomes widespread around the world, we are today confronted with what is perhaps one of the most important issues not just relating to the world of technology, but of humankind itself. The advent of ChatGPT, the generative AI tool developed by OpenAI, which together with others of similar ilk, has the possibility of changing the world as we know it. GPT—or generative pre-trained transformer—can quickly absorb and mimic human-like responses by deep learning garnered from millions of sources it absorbs from. This form of AI is a quantum leap in technology and has the potential to make far-reaching changes across healthcare, financial services, manufacturing, logistics, entertainment and indeed every other sector you can think of. In short, it can be all-pervasive. OpenAI has now released GPT-4, an even more advanced version of GPT.

But while AI in general is widely accepted as a boon for society, serious concerns have also been raised about the damage it can do. And it's not just about taking away jobs. If misused, AI has the power to spread misinformation, and cause hate and destruction, that can lead to disastrous consequences for the world at large. Some of the world's top technology experts feel that its powers can prove to be so pervasive that unless there are guardrails, AI in its unbridled form can be a serious threat to mankind. It is in that context that over 1,000 signatories signed a letter in March this year, asking AI labs for a six-month halt to training AI systems that are more powerful than GPT-4. The signatories included the likes of Tesla Founder Elon Musk and Apple Co-founder Steve Wozniak. While it is accepted that AI can have widespread positive effects and be a blessing for humankind, its dangers are equally frightening. Billionaire investor Warren Buffett has also compared AI to the atom bomb. But technology, as it has been seen several times in history, cannot be stopped in its tracks. So, the big question today is, how can one control the AI juggernaut, curb its negative aspects and put it to the best use for humanity.

In our cover package in this issue, we take a deep look into various aspects of AI and how it is impacting the world of business across sectors. BT's reporters talk to a wide range of sector players to understand how they are using AI in their businesses, the several benefits they are deriving, and how it is shaping the future. As *Rachna Dhanrajani* writes in her opening essay, AI could take away mundane, repetitive jobs but create new ones in programming and data science. But alongside, Prof. Stuart Russell of the University of California, who is one of the signatories to the letter with Musk and Wozniak, explains to BT's Tech Editor *Aayush Ailawadi* why he feels guardrails are needed for further development of AI. Calling for "reasonable guidelines that a system has to satisfy", Russell says: "If you can't build an airplane that doesn't fall out of the sky, you don't get to put passengers on it." Will the AI labs comply? The world is watching. **BT**

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